
GUIDELINES AND GRADING CRITERIA FOR FINAL PROJECTS AND PROPOSALS

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This document contains guidelines and rough grading criteria for your final projects (please note that these might be subject to minor changes). It is intended as a guideline to help you structure your write-up and as a general checklist for your submission. If certain criteria are not applicable to individual projects (e.g., there are no submitted datasets), the respective criteria and expectations will not be considered.

1 Structure of proposals for your projects

Please submit a **max. 1-page long document** via an email addressed to all three lecturers by no later than August 31st, 2025. The proposal should contain the following information / rough structure:

- short task definition
- example of task, if applicable
- motivation (e.g., against current literature; no need for long literature review)
- short definition of concrete hypotheses you plan to investigate, if applicable
- data description (data source, size, collection procedure if applicable); input and desired output specification
- training / evaluation: score and procedure specification

2 Write-up / Paper

Expectations There is a standard structure for scientific papers reporting (experimental) studies (e.g., in NLP, ML, psychology, linguistics etc.). Please stick to this structure unless you have very good reasons to diverge from it. Supporting formatting (including the appropriate reference style) is offered by the ACL paper template which you should use for your write-up of your final project. The template can be found here: https://2023.aclweb.org/calls/style_and_formatting/ (Overleaf is recommended) The paper should have the following sections in this order (you can choose subsections as you wish, if needed):

1. Abstract: short summary of the paper (up to 150 words). Should include the conclusion of your study.
2. Introduction: introduction, motivation and explanation of the research question in the context of the field / the class, explaining why it is interesting / novel in comparison to extant related work. Note that it is NOT mandatory to include an *exhaustive* literature review; it is sufficient to mention relevant work from the project proposals and the class materials.
3. Methods: detailed description of the study addressing the research question (including all details of, e.g., the models, datasets, used analyses, annotation schemes, etc...). It should enable another person reading your paper to fully replicate the study. No results or interpretation should be included yet.

4. Results: results of the study, presented, e.g., as a table, figure or described in words, description of the results of statistical analyses (if applicable). An interpretation with respect to the research question and the tested hypotheses should be included.
5. Discussion: reflection on the results in light of the research question, discussion of limitations of the current study and possible future directions for research. What worked, what didn't (why, if you have ideas)? This could include ideas that you had during the project that you think would be interesting to explore.
6. Conclusion (optional, could be combined with the discussion)
7. Acknowledgments (optional, should be used to acknowledge collaboration with other groups or, e.g., usage of coding & writing assistants, other people's code etc.)
8. References (to be provided in the style offered by the ACL template)

The idea of the write-up is to *communicate* the idea, approach, results and your own critical interpretation of the project. You can think of it as an hourglass-shaped story which should start with a somewhat broad description of the research question, then zoom in on the details of the procedure and results and then zoom out again, providing an interpretation of the results with respect to the initial research question. The writing should be scientific (i.e., use and explain scientific terms as appropriate) which, importantly, is not equivalent to being complicated. When writing, try to picture a fellow researcher in the field who, however, has no idea about your project, as the target audience.

Here are some potentially useful hints on the order of steps for writing the paper (the project write-up, but also scientific papers, in general):¹

1. Write easy things first
2. Make notes on Introduction
3. Write Methods
4. Write Results
5. Write Introduction
6. Write Discussion and Conclusion
7. Write Abstract

Grading Criteria like the following will be used for grading the paper as part of the final project (most criteria will be scales. Example: 0 points if a criterion is not fulfilled at all, 5 points if the paper is perfect in that regard):

- Are all relevant paper sections included (with relevant and clearly structured content)?
- Are correctly formatted references included?
- Are the research question, the hypotheses and the purpose of the study clearly stated?
- Is an interpretation of the results with respect to the research question provided?
- Is the study / results conceptually sound and correct (where applicable)?
- Is there a link to the full study materials?
- Are the chosen / created models, datasets and their contents / set-up described? (type of tasks in dataset, number of parameters in model, size of dataset, ...)
- Are the used evaluation metrics / statistical analyses clearly reported?
- Are the figure(s) / table(s) appropriate, readable, referenced in the text?
- Is the writing styles scientific (including correct grammar and spelling), are technical terms used correctly?
- Is the paper self-contained and intelligible to an uninformed reader from the field?

3 Code

If your project contains code, it should be submitted in some repository or storage together with your paper. The purpose of sharing the code is to enhance replicability of the studies and comply with best practices of open science. Therefore, the code (and the datasets, if they are provided) should, ideally, facilitate potential replications and extensions of your work and should, therefore, be well-documented and understandable for uninformed readers.

¹Thanks to Konstantin Sering who kindly shared these materials and initially provided them for his Psycholinguistics course in WS2023-24.

Expectations The submitted repository should contain the following:

- at least one README file explaining the structure and contents of the repo
- scripts used to run the study, obtain and analyse results
- a requirements file
- scripts or instructions on how to obtain models, datasets etc. that are used in the study. Note that datasets or model files that you did not modify should NOT be included in the submission.
- other relevant code

Grading Criteria like the following will be used for grading the coding and dataset part of the final project (most criteria will be scales. Example: 0 points if a criterion is not fulfilled at all, 5 points if the code / repo / data is perfect in that regard):

- Are the materials complete?
- Is the repository well-documented and structured?
- Is the code well-documented and easy to read (meaningful variable names, comments, docstrings)?
- Is the code reproducible (in a loose sense)? Can it be run without additional instructions / prior knowledge?
- Is the code functional?
- Is the code an adequate realization of the study and the research question?
- How difficult was the compilation of the materials?
- If a dataset is submitted: is the dataset well-documented, is its structure comprehensive?
- Applicable to the entire submission: Is the submission on time?
- Extra points: Are there any outstanding pieces of code, particularly thoughtful datasets, analyses or similar?

4 Checklist for miscellaneous points

When submitting your project, please check the following non-exhaustive list of points (not graded, just for your and my convenience):

- Are the names of all group members and their matriculation numbers and number of credits on the submission?
- Is the project title on the paper?